



US History I: The Constitutional Convention — Compromise in Practice — A Full Source-Analysis Session

US History I • History

COURSE-OBJ.HIST101.2

Explain the specific conflicts behind the Great Compromise and the Three-Fifths Compromise, and evaluate what each compromise resolved and what it left unresolved. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

US History I · History; COURSE-OBJ.HIST101.2 — Analyze how the Great Compromise and the Three-Fifths Compromise each resolved a specific conflict at the 1787 Constitutional Convention, and evaluate the tradeoffs each compromise created.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · read both sources + vocabulary 15 min · guided compromise-comparison organizer 18 min · partner evaluation discussion 18 min · independent practice 22 min · extension work 5 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

Virginia Plan — proposed representation in Congress based on state population

New Jersey Plan — proposed equal representation per state regardless of population

Great Compromise — created a bicameral Congress: House by population, Senate equal

Three-Fifths Compromise — counted each enslaved person as $\frac{3}{5}$ for representation and taxation

bicameral — a legislature with two separate chambers

direct tax — a federal tax calculated in part using state population

Concept focus

The 1787 Constitutional Convention nearly collapsed over how states would be represented in the new Congress. Large states backed the Virginia Plan (representation by population); small states backed the New Jersey Plan (equal representation per state), fearing large states would dominate. The Great Compromise (Connecticut Compromise) created a bicameral Congress: the House by population, the Senate equal per state. A second, harder conflict was whether enslaved people would count toward a state's population for representation and taxation. The Three-Fifths Compromise counted each enslaved person as three-fifths of a person for both purposes — a deliberately partial, dehumanizing formula that gave slaveholding states more congressional power than their free population alone would have earned, without acknowledging enslaved people's full humanity or granting them any rights.

Model 1 — Reading the representation conflict

Virginia (large population) wanted representation by population, which would give it more seats than small states like Delaware. Delaware wanted equal representation per state, protecting its voice regardless of population. Neither side would ratify a Constitution built entirely on the other's plan.

Model 2 — Reading the compromise formula

The Three-Fifths Compromise: a state with 100,000 free residents and 40,000 enslaved people would count $100,000 + (40,000 \times \frac{3}{5}) = 124,000$ people for representation — more seats than its free population alone would earn, but fewer than counting all 140,000 residents equally.



WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. What was the core disagreement between the Virginia Plan and the New Jersey Plan?

2. Why did small states like Delaware and New Jersey specifically oppose the Virginia Plan?



Source A: The Convention Debate, Summer 1787

By mid-June 1787, the convention delegates meeting in Philadelphia were at an impasse. Delegates from Virginia, the most populous state, had proposed what became known as the Virginia Plan: a Congress with representation based on each state's population, along with an executive and judiciary chosen partly through that legislature. Large states supported this plan because it reflected their greater population, and delegates like James Madison argued that a government should represent people, not simply the abstract entity of a "state."

Delegates from smaller states, including New Jersey and Delaware, rejected this framework outright. William Paterson of New Jersey introduced a rival proposal, the New Jersey Plan, keeping something closer to the existing Articles of Confederation structure: one vote per state, regardless of population. Small-state delegates argued that population-based representation would let a handful of large states dominate every vote, effectively erasing small states' influence in the national government they were being asked to join.

The debate grew heated enough that several delegates threatened to walk out, and for a period in late June and early July, the convention itself appeared close to collapse. Roger Sherman and Oliver Ellsworth of Connecticut proposed a middle path: a two-chamber legislature, with one chamber (the House of Representatives) apportioned by population, satisfying large states, and a second chamber (the Senate) giving each state two votes regardless of size, satisfying small states. On July 16, 1787, this proposal — the Great Compromise, or Connecticut Compromise — passed by a narrow vote of five states to four, breaking the deadlock and allowing the convention to continue.



Source B: The Representation-and-Taxation Problem

Even after the Great Compromise resolved how many representatives each state would have relative to other states, a second, harder question remained: when counting a state's population to determine that number of representatives (and, separately, to calculate direct taxes owed to the federal government), would enslaved people be counted at all?

Delegates from Southern states, where enslaved people made up a large share of the total population, argued for counting enslaved people fully for the purpose of representation — which would significantly increase those states' number of seats in the House — while generally preferring not to count them for taxation, which would reduce what those states owed. Delegates from Northern states, where slavery was less economically central, argued the opposite on each point: they opposed counting enslaved people for representation, since enslaved people had no political rights or voice, but were more willing to count them for taxation purposes.

The convention settled on a single formula applied to both calculations: each enslaved person would count as three-fifths of a person, both for determining a state's number of representatives and for calculating direct taxes. This satisfied neither side's underlying principle — it was not based on any coherent argument about a person being "three-fifths human" — but it was a numerical compromise that both blocs could accept because it produced a workable, if deeply unjust, middle number between "count fully" and "do not count at all." The compromise gave slaveholding states meaningfully more congressional power and influence in presidential elections (through the Electoral College, which was tied to House seats) than their free population alone would have earned, while enslaved people themselves gained no rights, representation, or voice from being "counted" at all.



State the answer or claim it supports.

Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. With a partner, explain why Northern delegates took the reverse position from Southern delegates on the same two questions.

2. With a partner, discuss: the lesson states the three-fifths formula "was not based on any coherent argument about a person being three-fifths human." What does this reveal about how the compromise was actually reached?

3. Discuss: Source B states the compromise "satisfied neither side's underlying principle." Explain what each side's underlying principle actually was.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. Using Source B, explain how the Three-Fifths Compromise affected presidential elections, not just Congress.

2. Evaluate: did the Three-Fifths Compromise give enslaved people any rights or representation? Justify your answer using Source B.

3. Compare the Great Compromise and the Three-Fifths Compromise: what problem did each one solve, stated in one sentence each?



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. Using evidence from both sources, explain why the convention needed two separate compromises rather than one.

5. A classmate claims "the Great Compromise and the Three-Fifths Compromise were basically the same kind of compromise." Evaluate this claim using specific evidence from both sources.

6. Explain what "direct taxes" refers to in Source B, and why Southern states' position on counting enslaved people for taxation might seem surprising at first.



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. Write a two-to-three sentence evaluation of the Great Compromise: what did it successfully solve, and what tension (if any) do you think it may have left unresolved for the future?

2. Write a two-to-three sentence evaluation of the Three-Fifths Compromise using the vocabulary term "tradeoff." Whose tradeoff was it, and whose was it not?



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Using both sources, write a short paragraph (4-5 sentences) explaining how the convention "solved" its representation problems through compromise, and evaluate whether "solved" is the right word for both compromises.

2. Explain why historians describe the Constitution produced by this convention as a document built on compromise rather than consensus.



Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Self-assessment: which compromise do you feel you can explain more confidently — the Great Compromise or the Three-Fifths Compromise — and which specific detail do you want to review again?



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. The Virginia Plan proposed representation in Congress based on state population; the New Jersey Plan proposed equal representation per state regardless of population — large and small states disagreed over which principle should govern.
2. They feared that population-based representation would let a handful of large states dominate every vote, effectively erasing small states' influence in the national government.
3. The House of Representatives is apportioned by population (satisfying large states); the Senate gives each state two votes regardless of population (satisfying small states).
4. The convention came close to collapsing; the passage states several delegates threatened to walk out and the convention "appeared close to collapse" in late June and early July, with the compromise passing by a narrow vote of five states to four.
5. Representation in the House of Representatives, and the calculation of direct taxes owed to the federal government.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. Southern delegates wanted enslaved people counted fully for representation (to gain more House seats) but not counted for taxation (to owe less tax); this was self-interested rather than inconsistent — in both cases, they were arguing for whichever count benefited their states most.
7. Northern delegates opposed counting enslaved people for representation (since enslaved people had no political rights or voice, they saw this as unjustly inflating Southern power) but were more willing to count them for taxation, which would raise what Southern states owed — again, a position aligned with what benefited Northern states' relative power.
8. It reveals the formula was a purely numerical, political compromise between two competing self-interested positions (count fully vs. not at all), not a principled judgment about the value or humanity of enslaved people — a middle number both blocs could accept, unrelated to any moral reasoning.
9. The South's underlying (self-interested) principle was maximizing representation while minimizing taxation; the North's underlying principle was the reverse. The three-fifths formula gave neither side their full preferred outcome on either count, since it was fully applied to both.
10. Because Electoral College votes were tied to a state's total number of representatives (House seats plus senators), counting enslaved people as three-fifths of a person for representation also gave slaveholding states more Electoral College votes than their free population alone would have earned.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. No — Source B explicitly states enslaved people "gained no rights, representation, or voice from being counted at all"; the count affected only how much political power slaveholding states held, not enslaved people's own status or rights.
12. The Great Compromise solved how state population should determine congressional representation between large and small states; the Three-Fifths Compromise (nominally) resolved whether and how much enslaved people would count toward that same representation and toward taxation.
13. The two conflicts were distinct: the Great Compromise addressed disagreement between large and small states over population-based representation in general, while the Three-Fifths Compromise addressed a separate disagreement between Northern and Southern states specifically over whether enslaved people counted toward that population — resolving one did not resolve the other.
14. This claim oversimplifies: the Great Compromise balanced two competing but comparably-positioned political interests (large vs. small states) through a structural solution (two chambers); the Three-Fifths Compromise resolved a conflict over counting actual human beings for political and financial advantage, with those human beings having no voice in the outcome — a fundamentally different kind of compromise involving actual injustice, not just competing state interests.
15. Direct taxes were federal taxes owed by each state, calculated in part using population; it might seem surprising that Southern states, who wanted enslaved people counted for representation, did not also want them counted for taxation — but their position was consistently about maximizing power while minimizing cost to their states, not about any single fixed formula.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Answers vary; must credit the Great Compromise with resolving the large-state/small-state representation deadlock, and may note ongoing tension over how well the Senate's equal-representation structure serves a nation with vastly different state populations, then and now.

17. Answers vary; must correctly use "tradeoff" to describe how Northern and Southern state delegates traded political and financial advantage against each other, while explicitly noting that enslaved people themselves had no say in or benefit from that tradeoff at all.

18. Answers vary; must summarize both compromises accurately and offer a reasoned evaluation — likely noting the Great Compromise genuinely resolved its specific structural conflict, while the Three-Fifths Compromise "resolved" the delegates' political conflict but did not resolve, and in fact entrenched, a deep moral and human injustice.

19. Neither large vs. small states nor North vs. South ever fully agreed on a single shared principle; instead, each conflict was resolved through a negotiated middle position (two chambers; a fractional count) that let delegates with opposing interests accept a document none of them considered ideal, rather than one built on genuine shared agreement.

20. Answers vary; must name one compromise and one specific detail (e.g., the exact vote count, the formula's application to both representation and taxation) for review.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment • accessed September 18, 2026

COURSE-OBJ.HIST101.2 — Analyze how the Great Compromise and the Three-Fifths Compromise each resolved a specific conflict at the 1787 Constitutional Convention, and evaluate the tradeoffs each compromise created. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the course-level goal.

Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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